see a film at Amreesh Cinema.

"It was fun watching English movies," says Ali Mohammad Khan, 55, a former wood artisan from Srinagar. "As young boys, we would mimic the characters and dress up like Englishmen." At Palladium cinema, owned by a Sikh family, people were often heard telling the owner: '*Sardarji, kuchh karo, Hajj karoge, ek Ticket do* (Sardarji, please give us a ticket, god will bless you).'

Post-Independence, it didn't take long for Hindi filmmakers to flock to Kashmir to capture its lofty and lush green pines and Dal Lake on celluloid. The first film to be shot in Kashmir, as per Dhar, was Raj Kapoor's *Barsaat* (1949). By the 1960s, Kashmir became a popular shooting spot, thanks to Shammi Kapoor-starrers *Junglee* (1961) and *Kashmir Ki Kali* (1964), followed by other films like *Jab Jab Phool Khile* (1965) and *Mere Sanam* (1965). "Locals and actors interacted often—you wouldn't find that happening anywhere else in India," says Dhar.



REUTERS

The launch of the INOX multiplex was followed by a screening of Aamir Khan-starrer *Laal Singh Chaddha*. The cinema will be opened to the public on Oct. 1

HOW THINGS FELL APART

For young lovebirds, the dark cinema halls used to be a regular hangout, apart from the shade of chinar trees in Mughal Gardens. Bands of young, rowdy men around theatres selling tickets in black were often an irritant. Zareef Ahmad Zareef, a prominent satirist from Kashmir, recalls how the "cinema-blackers"—as they were commonly known—were frowned upon as "*mawalis*" (hoodlums). But as militancy spread in the late '80s, many of them signed up as militants. For example, it's a well-known fact that Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front commander Farooq Ahmad Dar alias Bitta Karate, who is accused of murdering Kashmiri Pandits, used to sell tickets in black at Neelam Cinema.

Till 1989, Srinagar was home to 10 single-screen theatres. Shah, Firdous and Naaz are still standing, but lie deserted; Shiraz and Neelam are now home to CRPF camps; Khayam made way for Khyber hospital, while Regal, which was famous for having a special box for the Maharaja, is becoming a shopping complex. Palladium is in ruins—unidentifiable.

The closure of cinemas was especially painful for Kashmiri artistes. Writer-director Hussein Khan, who hails from Kashmir and directed his debut movie *Kashmir Daily* in 2017, had to plead his case before the chief minister so as to be able to screen the film at the SKICC auditorium on the banks of Dal Lake. Now, working on his new film, *Kashmir Se*, the 54-year-old is hopeful that his upcoming film will be screened in the Valley. However, he is not very optimistic about the success of cinemas in the region as decades of political turmoil have crushed the cine-going culture. Hussein suggests that local films be screened to rekindle the love for cinema among the masses. "Opening a cinema hall is not enough. It takes effort to sustain it," he says.

When Dhar told other cinema-owners in the Valley of his plans to open a multiplex, he sensed keenness. Dhar himself has informed authorities that he wishes to set up cinemas in Baramulla and Sopore. Films are back in other parts of Kashmir as well. Chennai-based entertainment startup Jadooz has set up mini-theatres in Pulwama and Shopian and plans to open 25 more at other places in Jammu & Kashmir.

Cinemas may have been targets of militants in the past, but INOX, for now, has chosen to look beyond that fear. "Watching cinema is in the DNA of every Indian. Nobody can take it away from us," says Alok Tandon, the CEO of INOX. "There's a special relationship between the Hindi film industry and Kashmir. That cultural exchange was missed in the last three decades." The local administration has ensured tight security by deputing 30 CRPF officers at the INOX multiplex, says Dhar.

The entry of the multiplex giant has also created job opportunities, with at least 60 locals filling in various positions. INOX has been training staff to sell tickets and handle housekeeping, projection, marketing and finance.

Walking around the INOX foyer, Dhar says modestly that the multiplex is "slightly better" than others across India. The aesthetics speak for his fondness. The INOX signage has been made with the famous papier mâché art of the region. The foyer ceiling and the doors of all three screens are designed with 'khatambandh', the exquisite wood carving of Kashmir. Similarly, Tandon talks of the need to "merge with the local architectural language" and says that INOX plans to introduce some Kashmiri cuisine at the food court.

The significance of the multiplex is not lost on anyone, especially Dhar. "Most businesses you do from the head, but some are done from the heart," he says. And there is no doubt where his latest initiative comes from. ■